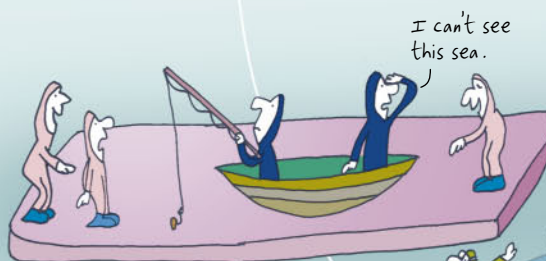


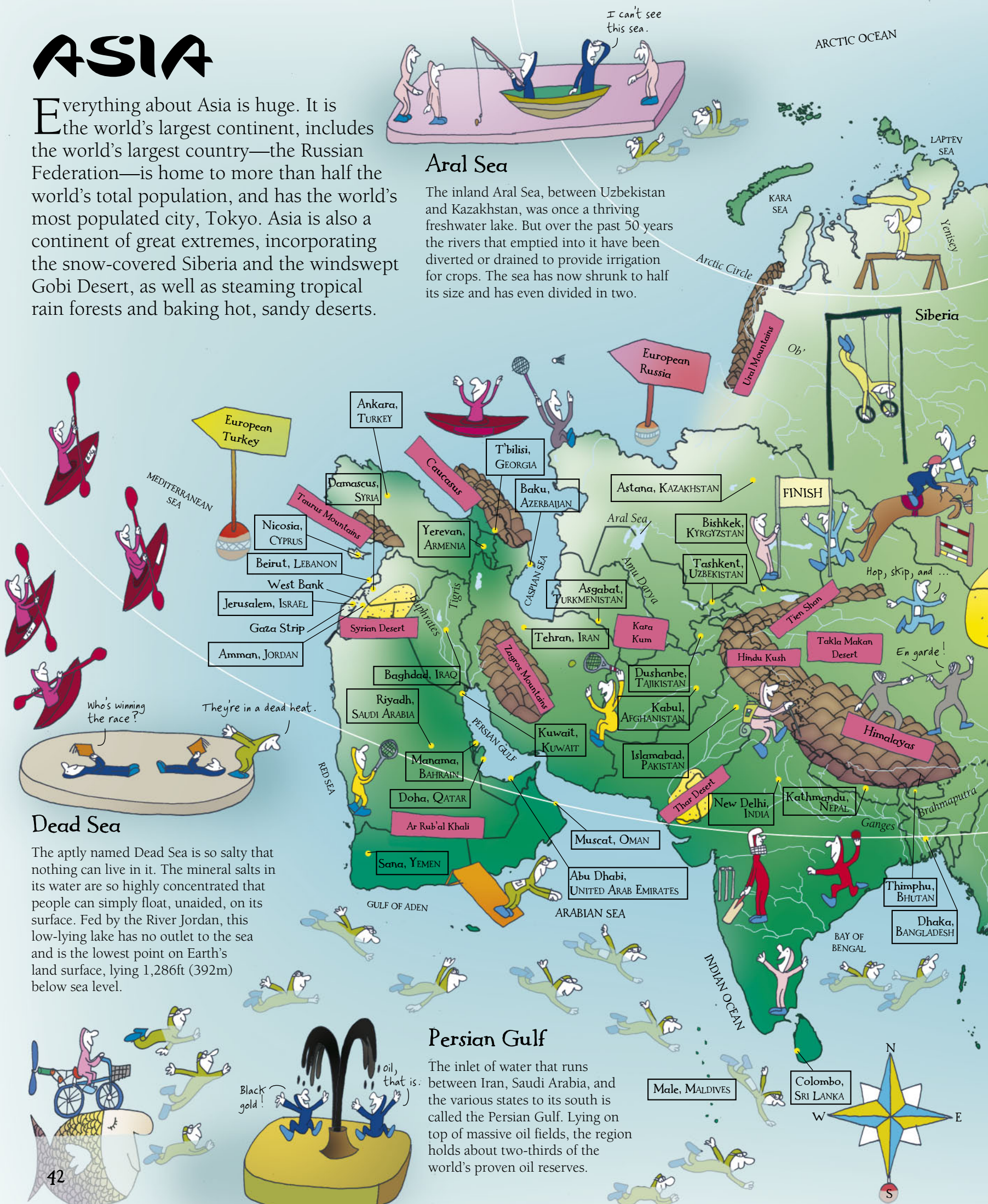
ASIA

Everything about Asia is huge. It is the world's largest continent, includes the world's largest country—the Russian Federation—is home to more than half the world's total population, and has the world's most populated city, Tokyo. Asia is also a continent of great extremes, incorporating the snow-covered Siberia and the windswept Gobi Desert, as well as steaming tropical rain forests and baking hot, sandy deserts.



Aral Sea

The inland Aral Sea, between Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan, was once a thriving freshwater lake. But over the past 50 years the rivers that emptied into it have been diverted or drained to provide irrigation for crops. The sea has now shrunk to half its size and has even divided in two.



Dead Sea

The aptly named Dead Sea is so salty that nothing can live in it. The mineral salts in its water are so highly concentrated that people can simply float, unaided, on its surface. Fed by the River Jordan, this low-lying lake has no outlet to the sea and is the lowest point on Earth's land surface, lying 1,286ft (392m) below sea level.

Persian Gulf

The inlet of water that runs between Iran, Saudi Arabia, and the various states to its south is called the Persian Gulf. Lying on top of massive oil fields, the region holds about two-thirds of the world's proven oil reserves.